BRIEFING

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Sudan's humanitarian crisis: Needs and responses



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Sudan's humanitarian crisis: Needs and responses

ABSTRACT

The Sudanese civil war has created the largest humanitarian emergency in the world. Since violence broke out in April 2023, fighting between the two main parties to the conflict – the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces – has not eased. As third countries have continued offering financial and military support to both parties, the situation of civilian Sudanese has continued to deteriorate. In 2026, more than 30 million people in the country need humanitarian assistance and over 15 million have been displaced.

The EU and its Member States are the largest humanitarian donor for Sudan, helping with food distribution, nutrition, health, water, and other areas of need. Nonetheless, humanitarian assistance in Sudan generally faces several critical challenges. Cuts to aid budgets have led to an underfunded humanitarian system. In Sudan, this means that about 60 % of the funds needed were lacking in 2025. The delivery of aid also faces challenges as a result of ongoing fighting, violence against aid workers, and administrative hurdles. This complicates – and at times prevents – aid deliveries to a population that has faced widespread and systematic violations of international humanitarian and human rights law for three years.

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List of abbreviations

AU	African Union
CSOs	Civil Society Organisations
DG ECHO	Directorate-General for European Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations
DG INTPA	Directorate-General for International Partnerships
EC	European Commission
EEAS	European External Action Service
EP	European Parliament
ERRs	Emergency Response Rooms
EUSR	European Union Special Representative
HAB	Humanitarian Air Bridge
HAC	Humanitarian Aid Commission
HC	Humanitarian Coordinator
IDP	Internally displaced person
IGAD	Intergovernmental Authority on Development
INGOs	International non-governmental organisations
IPC	Integrated Food Security Phase Classification
LAS	League of Arab States
NGOs	Non-governmental organisations
OCHA	Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs
RSF	Rapid Support Forces
SAF	Sudanese Armed Forces
SGBV	Sexual and gender-based violence
SHF	Sudan Humanitarian Fund
UN	United Nations
UNHCR	United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees
UNHRC	United Nations Human Rights Council
UNICEF	United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund
WASH	Water, sanitation and hygiene
WFP	World Food Programme

1. Introduction

Sudan faces one of the gravest humanitarian crises in the world. Since the outbreak of the conflict between the national Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) and the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces (RSF) in April 2023, violence between armed actors has led to significant displacement, widespread food insecurity, and the collapse of basic services. According the European Commission (EC), more than 30 million people need humanitarian assistance, and over 15 million have been displaced internally and across borders. The scale, speed, and geographic spread of the crisis have placed extraordinary pressure on the Sudanese state and society, neighbouring countries, and international humanitarian actors and donors.

These challenges are exacerbated by the operational environment in which humanitarian aid must be delivered. Hostilities, bureaucratic restrictions, insecurity along supply routes, damaged infrastructure, and limited access to affected populations constrain response efforts. In several regions, particularly in western Sudan, humanitarian actors are operating in conditions of extreme insecurity, while displacement patterns remain fluid and unpredictable.

While the violence and its catastrophic humanitarian consequences have mostly played out in Sudan, the conflict is increasingly taxing the entire region. Approximately 3.5 million refugees have crossed into neighbouring countries since 2023. With the exception of Egypt, all of Sudan's neighbours were amongst the 20 most fragile countries in the world in 2024, according to the Fragile States Index of the Fund for Peace.

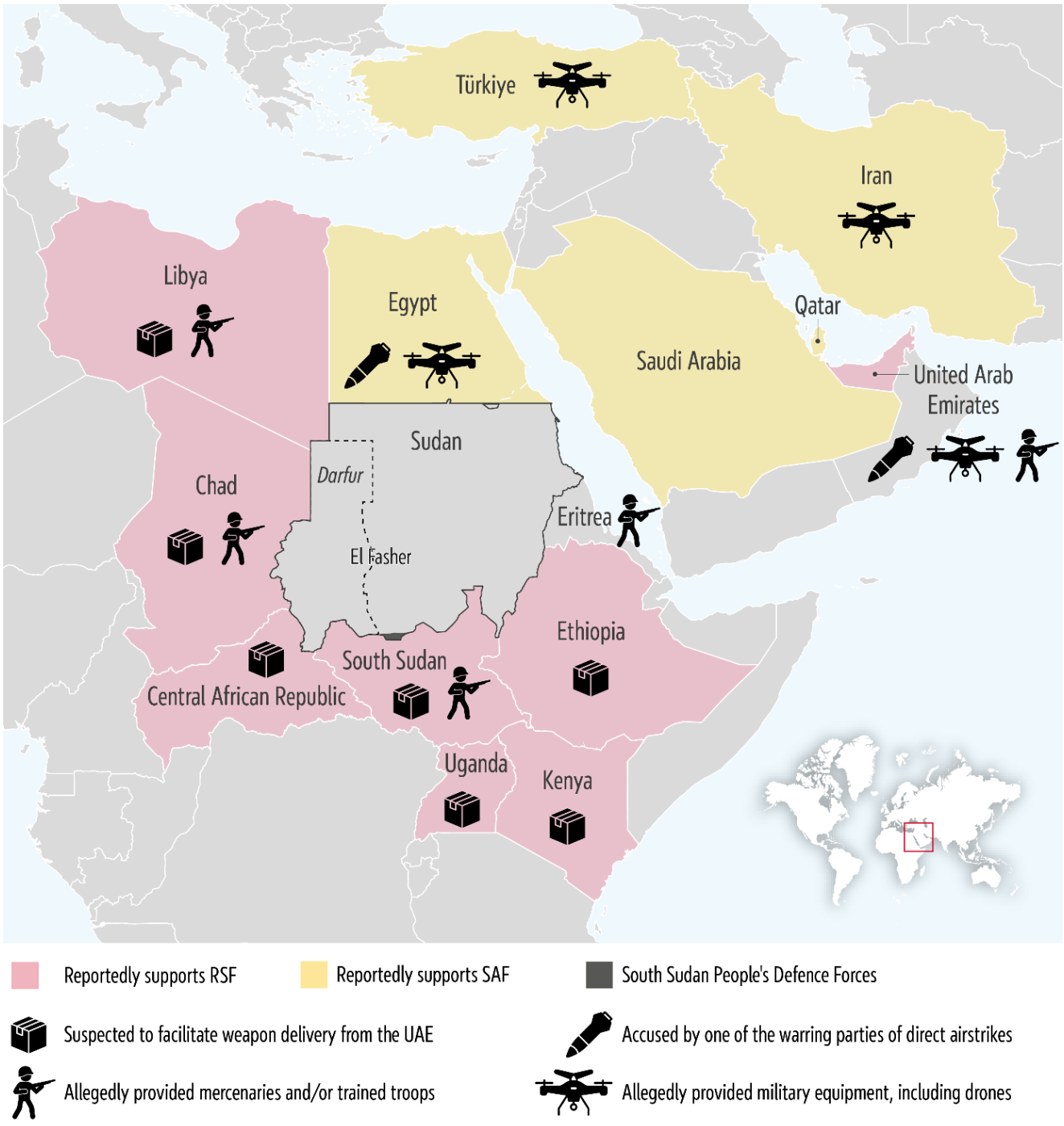
The warring parties in Sudan have also built extensive networks of external backing. Several neighbouring states and actors from the wider region are reportedly supplying logistics and military equipment, according to media reporting (see also Figure 1 below). In addition, reporting suggests that Egypt has enabled direct military assistance – mostly in the form of air support by unmanned aerial vehicles – in support of the SAF. The Sudanese government has accused Ethiopia of facilitating comparable assistance from its territory in support of the RSF.

This direct and indirect involvement of regional actors creates risks of a regional spillover of the conflict, beyond Sudan's borders. Analysts – for example at the European Union Institute for Security Studies (EUISS) – argue that the civil war is increasingly entangled in regional and global rivalries. As a consequence, competing interests from outside Sudan have bearing on the conflict. They range from security concerns in neighbouring countries, regional competition over hegemony, to interests in Sudanese resources, such as gold. Trying to reconcile these different stances may complicate conflict mediation and resolution.

The conflict has resulted in widespread and systematic violations of international humanitarian and human rights law. The Independent International Fact-Finding Mission for the Sudan of the UN Human Rights Council (UNHRC) has documented grave abuses by both warring parties. Civilians have been deliberately targeted, homes and livelihoods destroyed, and entire communities displaced. The UNHRC mission report describes large-scale RSF attacks in Darfur that have targeted Masalit and other non-Arab populations. Human Rights Watch has called these acts 'ethnic cleansing,' while the UNHCR mission

report found evidence of genocide. Civil society representatives, journalists, and human rights defenders have been threatened, attacked, and killed. Sexualised violence is widespread, affecting thousands of women and children. Women and girls are subjected to abduction, rape, and sexual slavery. Children have been recruited into armed groups, raped, and subject to other grave violations of their human rights. Humanitarian actors also face severe constraints on their access and systematic obstructions to their operations by both the SAF and the RSF. Both limit their ability to scale up operations.

Figure 1: Reported regional support to armed actors in Sudan



Source: EPRS; icons © xoawPic, creatix, DesiArt/Adobe Stock; data sources: UN, Africa Confidential, ECFR, ISPI, WI Fikra Forum, and other source, 2025.

Despite the scale of the emergency, the international response remains critically underfunded. The European Union (EU) has positioned itself as a leading humanitarian donor in Sudan. In 2025, the EU allocated EUR 273 million to Sudan and its neighbours to support life-saving assistance and protection interventions. Together with the EU Member States, the EU has in total pledged EUR 522 million for humanitarian, peace, and development funding for Sudan in 2025. EU support covers food distribution, nutrition, health, water and sanitation, shelter, and education in emergencies. It is primarily delivered through UN agencies and humanitarian partners. Despite this substantial financial commitment, the gap between needs and available resources remains significant. Cuts by major donors, including the United States, have had particularly severe consequences. As of December 2025, only around 39.4 % of Sudan's humanitarian funding requirements for the year had been met, according to the UN. Funding shortfalls, coordination challenges, and limited access continue to hinder the delivery of timely and adequate assistance.

The following sections examine the evolving humanitarian needs, the vulnerabilities of displaced and marginalised populations, the architecture for delivering humanitarian aid, the operational and funding challenges of humanitarian actors, and the EU's humanitarian response to the Sudan crisis. The analysis is based on a combination of desk research and 10 stakeholder interviews[1].

2. Background to the conflict

The ongoing civil war in Sudan began in April 2023 following a conflict over power sharing between the SAF and the RSF. The two groups had governed the country under joint military rule since assuming control in a military coup in 2021.

The outbreak of the civil war is commonly attributed to a fallout between the leader of the SAF, Abdel Fattah al-Burhan, and the leader of the RSF, Muhammad Hamdan 'Hemedti' Dagalo. A planned reform that would have seen the RSF formally integrated into the SAF in 2023. However, this was rejected by the RSF, whose leaders wanted maintain control of their troops.

Sudan has experienced regular and prolonged periods of civil war and war in the last decades. This includes the Sudanese civil war from 1983 to 2005, which led to the independence of South Sudan in 2011.

A second major conflict took place from 2003 to 2010 in the Darfur region in Sudan's west. During this conflict, Sudanese state-sponsored militias – the *Janjaweed* militias, from which the RSF originates – committed atrocities that some analysts and governments have characterised as genocide. The International Criminal Court (ICC) has indicted Sudan's former President Omar al-Bashir, whose government supported the *Janjaweed* militias, for war crimes and crimes against humanity in 2009, and for genocide in 2010. Al-Bashir remains imprisoned in Sudan and no trial at the ICC has yet been conducted.

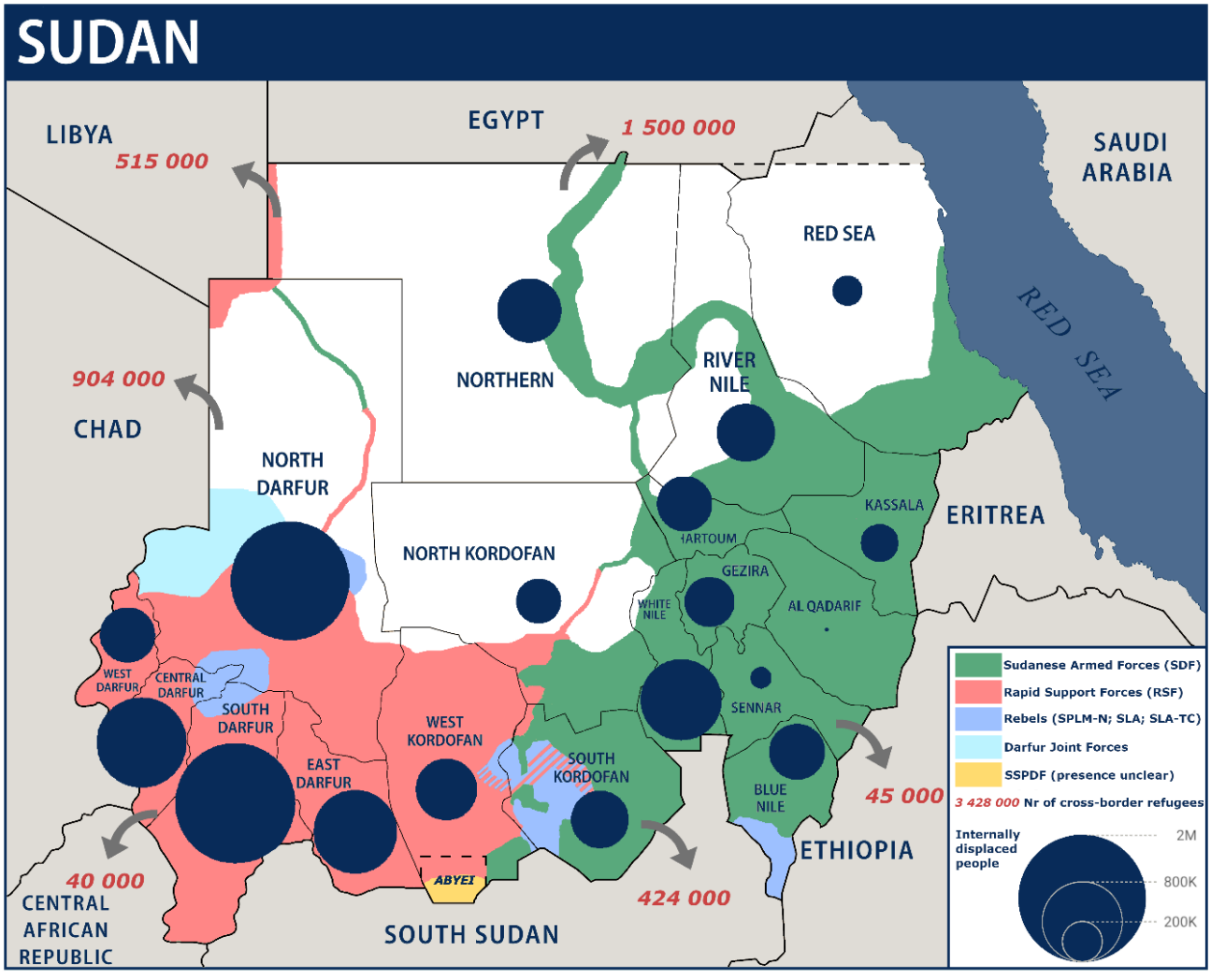
[1] Interviews were conducted in January and February 2026. Three interviews were conducted with EU officials (EU), two interviews with representatives of UN agencies active in Sudan (UN) and four interviews with local stakeholders and civil society (LS/CSOs). To protect anonymity, references to interviews only disclose to which of these three categories interviewees belong.

3. Humanitarian needs in Sudan

Since the outbreak of civil war, Sudan has descended into one of the gravest humanitarian and human rights crises in the world. Fatality estimates vary significantly, ranging from approximately 30 000 to 150 000 deaths since April 2023. Many deaths are caused not by direct violence, but by starvation and disease linked to the war. The war has triggered the world's largest displacement crisis. Over 11.5 million people are internally displaced within Sudan, while approximately 3.5 million have fled across borders into neighbouring countries such as Chad, Ethiopia, and South Sudan (see also Figure 2 below).

The food and nutrition situation is catastrophic. More than 21 million Sudanese, nearly half of the country's 50 million population, are facing acute food insecurity. According to the EU's Directorate-General for European Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations (ECHO), some areas of the country are already experiencing famine, and many more are at risk of famine.

Figure 2: IDPs, refugees and frontlines in Sudan in January 2026



Source: EXAS with data from UNHCR, OCHA, EEAS, Thomas van Linge. Disclaimer: This map does not reflect the official position of the EP or any other EU institution. Figures and other information are indicative and subject to rapid change.

Ongoing conflict, displacement, funding cuts, limited humanitarian access, and seasonal weather changes are expected to worsen the crisis further. The situation is especially grave

in the North Darfur State, in locations such as the city of El Fasher (the capital of the North Darfur State of Sudan), where supply routes have reportedly been blocked, civilians targeted along escape routes, and prohibitive fees imposed on those attempting to flee. UN analysts have referred to these obstructions of aid as 'a weaponisation of hunger', and the International Criminal Court is investigating possible war crimes and crimes against humanity in relation to the violence in El Fasher.

Outbreaks of infectious diseases have been reported throughout the country, with approximately 75 % of health facilities in conflict-affected areas out of service. Attacks on hospitals and health infrastructure have severely hampered responses to cholera and other disease outbreaks, and essential services have collapsed in many areas. Natural disasters, including floods and landslides, have compounded the crisis, further damaging infrastructure and complicating humanitarian operations. Shortages of food, clean water, medicines, fuel, electricity, and communications are widespread. Education has also been severely impacted; UNICEF estimates that about 16.5 million children – roughly 80 % of Sudan's children – are currently out of school.

Local actors and communities consistently identify psychosocial support and sustainable livelihoods as issues in need of attention (LS/CSL). The scale of trauma is creating great needs (LS/CSO). The provision of social support, counselling, and psychological rehabilitation to address widespread trauma is described by affected communities as a fundamental priority. Without addressing trauma, social fragmentation, and the psychological impact of violence, long-term recovery will remain elusive (LS/CSO).

Income-generating activities are also urgently needed (LS/CSO). Vocational training; start-up kits for small businesses; and support for women's cooperatives, youth associations, and micro-enterprise are seen as critical pathways toward resilience (LS/CSO). In displacement-affected communities and host regions alike, opportunities to earn income are particularly important for women and young people, who are disproportionately affected by unemployment and social exclusion (LS/CSO).

3.1 Displacement

Sudan's displacement crisis – the world's largest – has affected almost all regions, in both urban centres and more remote areas. Many Sudanese have had to relocate multiple times, often settling in areas characterised by high poverty, weak infrastructure, and very limited access to services (LS/CSO).

Several cross-cutting issues affect displaced populations across the region. Climate change and environmental degradation interact with conflict dynamics, intensifying competition over land and resources and contributing to new or secondary displacement. In neighbouring South Sudan, for example, evidence links climate-induced shocks (flooding and drought) to deeper gender inequality and increased violence against women and girls. Regional refugee response plans also underline the importance of integrating gender, age, and diversity considerations into all aspects of the response, including protection, livelihoods, education and access to basic services.

Overall, displacement related to the Sudan crisis is characterised by its exceptional scale, its regional reach and the severe vulnerabilities faced by affected populations. The combination of protracted conflict, weak state institutions, limited data and the

intersecting impacts of climate change and gender inequality means that displaced people are likely to require sustained humanitarian and development support for the foreseeable future.

3.1.1 Internally displaced persons

Displacement affects several distinct population groups whose situations and needs differ depending on location, the duration of their displacement, and pre-existing vulnerabilities. These groups consist of internally displaced persons (IDPs), refugees (primarily in Chad, South Sudan and Ethiopia), and returnees.

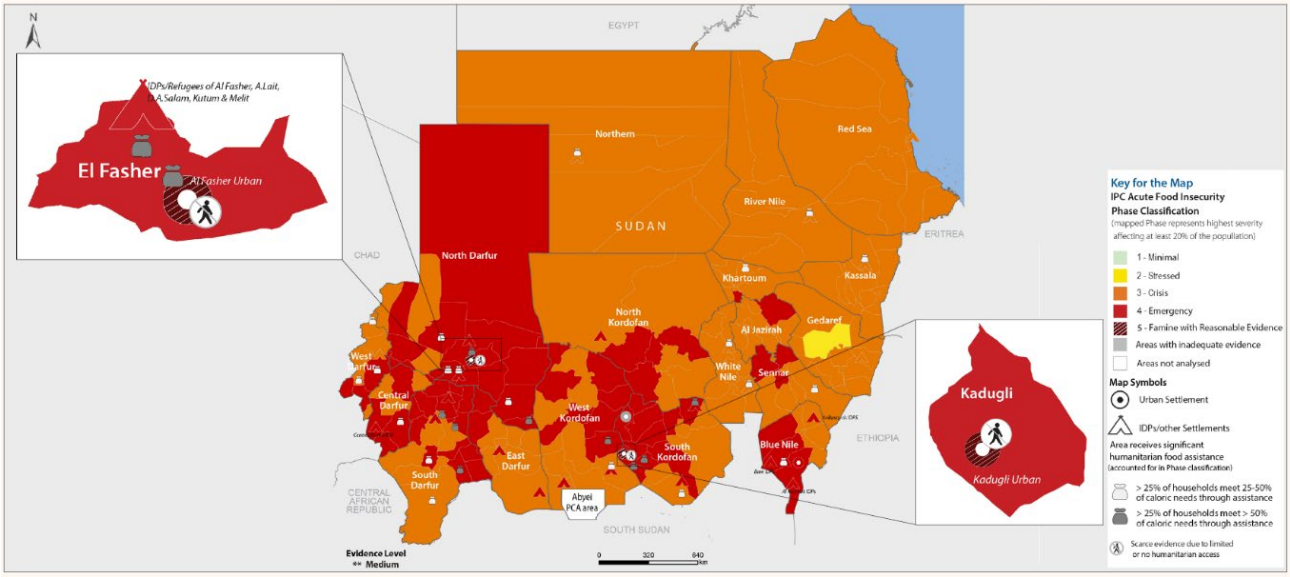
IDPs now number more than 11.5 million, often living in informal settlements, collective centres, or with host families. A majority lack adequate shelter and access to basic services. In addition, close to 1 million people that had fled to Sudan from other countries are still hosted in Sudan and have been displaced again by the civil war.

Returnees, who had previously fled the country, frequently find themselves – back in areas characterised by high poverty, limited infrastructure, and ongoing insecurity. Only a few returnees receive structured reintegration support amid underfunded programmes.

At the outbreak of the war, the capital, Khartoum, was the place in most acute need of humanitarian assistance. Although pockets of acute vulnerability remain in Khartoum, the city is gradually stabilising, with returns increasing and early recovery efforts becoming more relevant than large-scale emergency response. The gravest situation is now in Darfur, particularly North Darfur and across the Kordofan states (West, South, and North Kordofan). These regions account for the largest displacement flows and the most severe humanitarian conditions. Overall, while some areas in Sudan are transitioning toward recovery, western Sudan and Kordofan remain at the epicentre of displacement and humanitarian need. (See also Figure 2 above and Figure 3 below.)

The vulnerabilities of displaced people in Sudan are shaped by overlapping factors, such as food insecurity, loss of income, limited access to basic services, and heightened exposure to violence. According to surveys and situation reports released by the Integrated Food Security Phase Classification (IPC) initiative, up to 45 % of displaced households face high levels of acute food insecurity (IPC Phase 3 or above). This segment includes 6.3 million people in emergency conditions (IPC Phase 4 high acute malnutrition and excess mortality) and 375 000 (1 %) facing catastrophic malnutrition and famine (IPC Phase 5). Food insecurity is so widespread that almost every region of Sudan is experiencing at least crisis levels of food insecurity (see Figure 3 below). Access to clean, safe water, and appropriate sanitation has deteriorated. By October 2024, many regions reported highly dysfunctional health services, with two thirds of the population left without access to essential care. Access to education is disrupted by school closures and the use of schools as displacement sites (LS/CSO).

Figure 3: Food insecurity in Sudan in January 2026



Source: IPC. Disclaimer: this map does not reflect the official position of the EP or any other EU institution. Figures and other information are indicative and subject to rapid change.

The security situation of Sudanese, but especially of IDPs, is severely impacted by the conflict. Reports by humanitarian actors and observers describe attacks on displacement sites, repeated forced movements, and deliberate obstruction of humanitarian assistance, all of which increase the exposure of IDPs and refugees to violence and exploitation.

Women and girls face heightened risk of gender-based violence, including sexual violence, in and around camps, during flight, and when collecting firewood or water. Children are particularly vulnerable to family separation, recruitment by armed actors, child labour, and early or forced marriage, while older persons and people with disabilities often struggle to access information, assistance, and safe shelter.

3.1.2 Refugees in neighbouring countries

External displacement has reached a regional scale, as millions of people have crossed from Sudan into neighbouring countries, including Chad, Egypt, South Sudan, Ethiopia, the Central African Republic, and Libya. Regional refugee response plans for 2024 and 2025 highlight that these arrivals include both Sudanese nationals and refugees of other nationalities who had been living in Sudan before the current conflict. Many cross borders with very few possessions, arriving in remote, under-served border areas where reception capacity is limited, and basic services are already overstretched.

The onward impact on surrounding countries and host communities is significant. Host states in the east and Horn of Africa and the Great Lakes region face concurrent challenges, including their own internal displacement, protracted refugee situations, and high levels of food insecurity (LS/CSO). The sudden increase in population places additional pressure on health systems, schools, water points and shelter, often in regions that were already fragile or underserved before the Sudan crisis escalated. As a result, many displaced people spend extended periods in informal or poorly equipped sites, seeking shelter in schools, government buildings, and other public facilities (LS/CSO). Humanitarian actors emphasise

the need to support both refugees and host communities to prevent social tension and to maintain acceptance of displaced populations.

Support to Sudan and refugee-hosting neighbours is additionally provided in a nexus approach through DG INTPA. This includes projects supporting displaced populations and host communities in Sudan, South Sudan, Chad, Ethiopia, and the Central African Republic (CAR) (EU). Altogether, EUR 55 million has been programmed for this purpose (EU).

3.1.3 Impact on minorities and vulnerable groups

The Sudanese population has been subjected to grave human rights violations, war crimes, and crimes against humanity committed by both factions since the outbreak of the war, according to analysts and international investigations. The international fact finding mission of UNHRC reports that it found 'that the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) carried out a coordinated campaign of destruction against non-Arab communities in and around El Fasher, the hallmarks of which point to genocide.'

Women, girls, and children are at especially high risk of violence in Sudan (LS/CSO), not least because sexual and gender-based violence (SGBV) intersects with and accompanies the violence targeting different ethnic groups in the country. The UN-led Gender Based Violence Global Protection Cluster estimates that 12.1 million Sudanese women and girls are at risk of SGBV. This figure has almost doubled since the end of 2024, with displacement notably increasing the vulnerability of women and girls (LS/CSO). They face heightened exposure to sexual violence, exploitation, trafficking, and forced or early marriage.

Reports indicate that sexual violence has been used as a tactic of war (LS/CSO). Survivors often experience not only physical and psychological trauma but also face severe social stigma. For example, women and girls who become pregnant as a result of rape are often rejected by their communities leading to social isolation. Children born in these circumstances may be socially excluded from birth, compounding the trauma of their mothers. This stigma can also create barriers to essential services, with some children unable to be registered or access vaccinations and healthcare. Interviewees highlighted the need for conflict-sensitive and culturally responsive SGBV programming and psychosocial care (LS/CSO). Additionally, mental health and social rehabilitation services are described as underfunded and underprioritised compared to food and general medical aid.

Beyond SGBV, children are reported to face acute risks, including family separation, recruitment by armed groups, and psychosocial trauma (LS/CSO). According to the Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan (HNRP) for Sudan, children are at high risk of experiencing trauma, malnutrition, and displacement, with severe effects on their growth, development and wellbeing. In addition, the rights of many children are severely violated by trafficking, sexual violence, child marriage and labour, and recruitment into armed groups. Reported cases of abuse and exploitation indicate that Sudan is amongst the countries with the highest prevalence of such incidents globally.

Persons with disabilities face additional barriers in accessing humanitarian assistance, general services and information in humanitarian crises (LS/CSO). They are among the most invisible and disproportionately affected victims of the conflict (LS/CSO). Persons with disabilities often lack assistive devices, such as wheelchairs, and limited mobility

impedes the ability to seek shelter or access sanitation. Communication barriers further isolate children who are deaf, blind, or non-verbal. Interview partners further noted that the burden of care falls disproportionately on women.

4. Humanitarian aid architecture and challenges to humanitarian assistance in Sudan

4.1 The humanitarian aid architecture in Sudan

The response to the crisis in Sudan is politically complex, logistically demanding, and resource-intensive. Humanitarian assistance/support is delivered through a multi-layered system that includes community and local actors, non-governmental organisations (NGOs/INGOs), civil-society organisations (CSOs), UN agencies, donor governments and supranational bodies.

Funding from external donors – state donors and private individuals – flows into Sudan through several channels. Donors can earmark their contributions to NGOs or UN agencies for specific projects in specific locations. They can also make general contributions to UN agencies, which have operations in Sudan, without specifying how and where they should be used. UN agencies both implement directly and implement through sub-granted local partners. The UN also provides many of the political, legal, and logistical structures for the wider humanitarian community, by negotiating access, offering common services, and operating under UN privileges and immunities that many NGOs rely on to move staff and supplies and to operate safely (UN). A third mechanism is the Sudan Humanitarian Fund (SHF), a country-based, pooled fund managed by the UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) under the authority of the Humanitarian Coordinator (HC). SHF channels resources to both UN agencies and NGOs, which in turn may work with sub partners. Allocations follow HC decisions informed by strategic priorities, advisory board guidance, and technical review processes, allowing funds to be used rapidly and flexibly as needs evolve (UN).

The formal aid architecture in Sudan is coordinated through a cluster system, facilitated by the OCHA. Clusters bring together organisations working in the same sector, such as food security, nutrition, water and sanitation (WASH), protection, shelter, health, and education. For example, the food security cluster includes the World Food Programme, the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO), and international NGOs (UN). Within each cluster, partners identify geographic priorities, estimate needs based on their operational presence, and calculate the resources required (UN). This data informs the Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan and the Humanitarian Needs Overview (HNO), which outline how many people are in need, how many can realistically be targeted given funding constraints, and how much funding is required (UN). Where feasible and appropriate, partners seek collaboration with government counterparts for needs assessments (e.g., for food security). Where such collaboration is not possible due to access, security, or neutrality concerns, assessments are conducted independently using remote methods, such as key informant interviews, phone surveys, secondary data review, satellite imagery, and market monitoring (UN). Food insecurity severity is classified using the Integrated Food Security Phase Classification (IPC) system. Given that needs far exceed available resources, current

humanitarian assistance is highly targeted, prioritising populations facing the most severe conditions (UN).

In country, local actors and (formal and informal) local organisations are often the first responders. They operate informally at the grassroots level, often reaching people in need before other responders (LS/CSO). Two examples are Emergency Response Rooms (ERRs) and Takaaya. ERRs are grassroots, volunteer-driven, community-led initiatives that have emerged across Sudan in response to the country's deepening humanitarian crisis. Inspired by the Sudanese tradition of Nafeer, which embodies solidarity and collective action, the ERRs were initially self-funded and supported by the diaspora. However, since late 2023, ERRs have gained greater international recognition, and international humanitarian and development actors (IHDAs) have attempted to coordinate with them and provide support. Bringing together a voluntary network of medical professionals, engineers, and other specialists, they provide critical humanitarian assistance to more than four million people. Their work includes distributing food, clean water, and essential medicines, operating community kitchens and health clinics, and offering trauma counselling and support for survivors of sexual violence.

Takaaya (singular: Takiya) are community-run kitchens. Locally led, they are alternatives to conventional aid systems. Takaaya provide direct food support at the community level for areas facing acute food shortages and are often co-located with ERRs. These local initiatives represent the most localised humanitarian response in Sudan, built on community solidarity and indigenous knowledge rather than external programming.

Finally, there is a growing emphasis on connecting humanitarian action with early recovery and development when conditions allow (EU). In areas like Khartoum responses are gradually shifting toward recovery. On the other hand, in western Sudan, particularly Darfur and the Kordofans, is now the epicentre of acute humanitarian need and displacement (EU).

Overall, Sudan's aid architecture is highly coordinated and structured, with clear mechanisms for needs assessment, prioritisation, funding allocation, and sectoral coordination. However, it operates under severe funding constraints, access limitations, and a protection crisis that continues to deepen as the conflict persists.

4.2 Operational challenges for humanitarian assistance

Security conditions constitute the most impactful barrier to humanitarian assistance. Operating in Sudan is dangerous, particularly for national organisations (LS/CSO and EU). Health facilities and food convoys have been struck, not merely as collateral damage, but in some cases through deliberate targeting (LS/CSO and EU). Checkpoints, shifting frontlines, and fragmented command structures create unpredictable and high-risk environments (LS/CSO and EU). The EU is demanding continued and unhindered humanitarian access.

Inadequate or destroyed infrastructure is another impediment to humanitarian operations in Sudan. While aid is rarely blocked from entering Sudan, the delivery of humanitarian supplies faces immense challenges in reaching remote populations because of inadequate or destroyed infrastructure (LS/CSO). Local stakeholders and EU officials report that deliveries from Port Sudan to inland regions can take several weeks, passing through

insecure areas and multiple checkpoints (LS/CSO and EU). Poor infrastructure, including limited paved roads and minimal airport capacity, greatly increases operational costs and delays, impacting the timely delivery of humanitarian aid.

Another central issue concerns registration and authorisation. International and local humanitarian and development actors must formally register with a government body to obtain legal status and permission to operate in Sudan. Historically, this role has been held by the Humanitarian Aid Commission (HAC) of Sudan, controlled by the SAF since the outbreak of the war (LS/CSO). In areas under the control of the RSF, a parallel structure has been established: the Sudanese Agency for Relief and Humanitarian Operations (SARHO).

As a result, humanitarian actors are often required to navigate two competing administrative systems. Each authority imposes its own registration processes, reporting obligations, and approval mechanisms (EU). Permits are not always issued in a timely manner, and bureaucratic requirements frequently place additional strain on already overstretched organisations (EU and LS/CSO).

The multiplicity of authorities further complicates the secure delivery of humanitarian aid, as safe humanitarian corridors require agreement from the warring groups to ensure the security of aid deliveries. Some organisations operate simultaneously in areas controlled by the SAF and the RSF and in areas where control fluctuates (LS/CSO). This leads to coordination challenges requiring diplomatic skill: maintaining working relationships with all sides while safeguarding neutrality, transparency, and adherence to international humanitarian law. Interviewees state that local organisations are often able to ensure better access compared to some UN agencies or international NGOs, largely because their staff are locally recruited and embedded in the communities (LS/CSO).

In some cases, obtaining authorisation from one authority can create suspicion or rejection from another (LS/CSO). Both the SAF and RSF increasingly frame humanitarian operations through a security lens. Humanitarian actors express concerns that administrative restrictions may impede their assistance from reaching areas perceived to be aligned with opposing forces. OCHA further reports that 'volunteers with mutual aid groups continue to face arbitrary arrest, detention and abuse. In August [2025] alone, incidents of violence against volunteer aid workers were reported in Khartoum, East Darfur and North Darfur'.

Operational and access challenges vary by region. In the state of Gezira, for example, organisations report difficulties reaching survivors in certain locations and concerns about maintaining confidentiality when delivering protection services (LS/CSO). In the Northern States, authorities have at times restricted access to IDP camps, reportedly to discourage prolonged displacement and prevent camps from becoming permanent settlements (LS/CSO). Humanitarian access to areas under siege has also been denied. The UN, for example, reports that it was unable to access and deliver aid to more than 100 000 persons in need in El Fasher when the city was under siege by the RSF.

4.3 Coordination challenges

The humanitarian system in Sudan operates through a structured cluster mechanism designed to minimise overlap (UN). Within this system, facilitated by OCHA, agencies

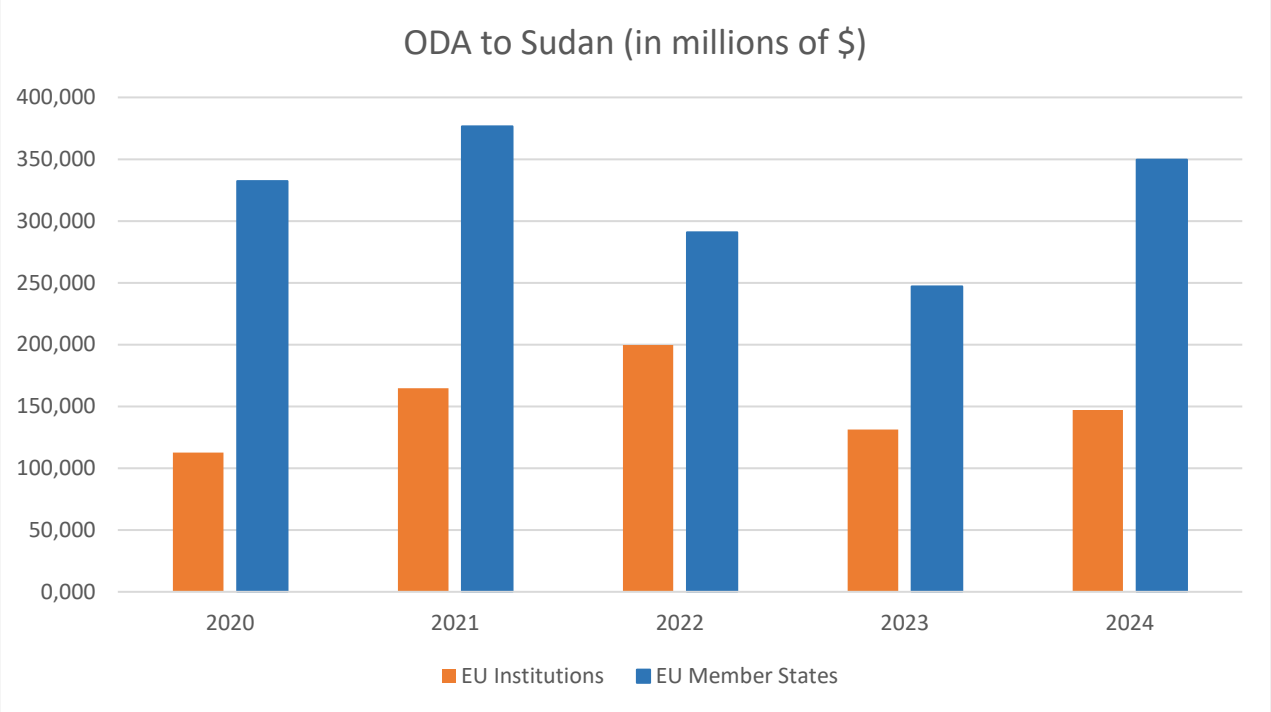
jointly assess needs, analyse where they are greatest, and allocate responsibilities to avoid duplicating assistance; their sectoral calculations are consolidated into an overall appeal, forming the basis of the Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan HNRP (UN). However, some actors – for example charitable organisations or biliteral initiatives by newer humanitarian donors – chose to operate outside this coordinated cluster framework, which has at times led to duplication.

Even though coordination at headquarters and capital levels is reported to function well, stronger coordination is needed at the state level (LS/CSO). Most coordination mechanisms currently rely on online meetings and virtual platforms, with only limited in-person engagement (LS/CSO). Given the situation in Sudan, local actors regularly face connectivity issues and have to rely on poor digital infrastructure, constraining their ability to coordinate. Since the outbreak of the war in 2023, several states, including Khartoum and Gezira, have experienced prolonged power outages and limited internet access (LS/CSO). In parts of Darfur, connectivity depends almost entirely on satellite-based internet services, most commonly through the Starlink system. Local stakeholders report that this heavy reliance on a single, private source creates significant vulnerability (LS/CSO). In hard-to-reach and northern areas, frequent electricity shortages further complicate operations (LS/CSO). Without stable power, organisations must depend on solar systems, which are themselves limited by weather conditions and availability. On days when solar power is insufficient, work may simply not be possible.

4.4 Funding challenges

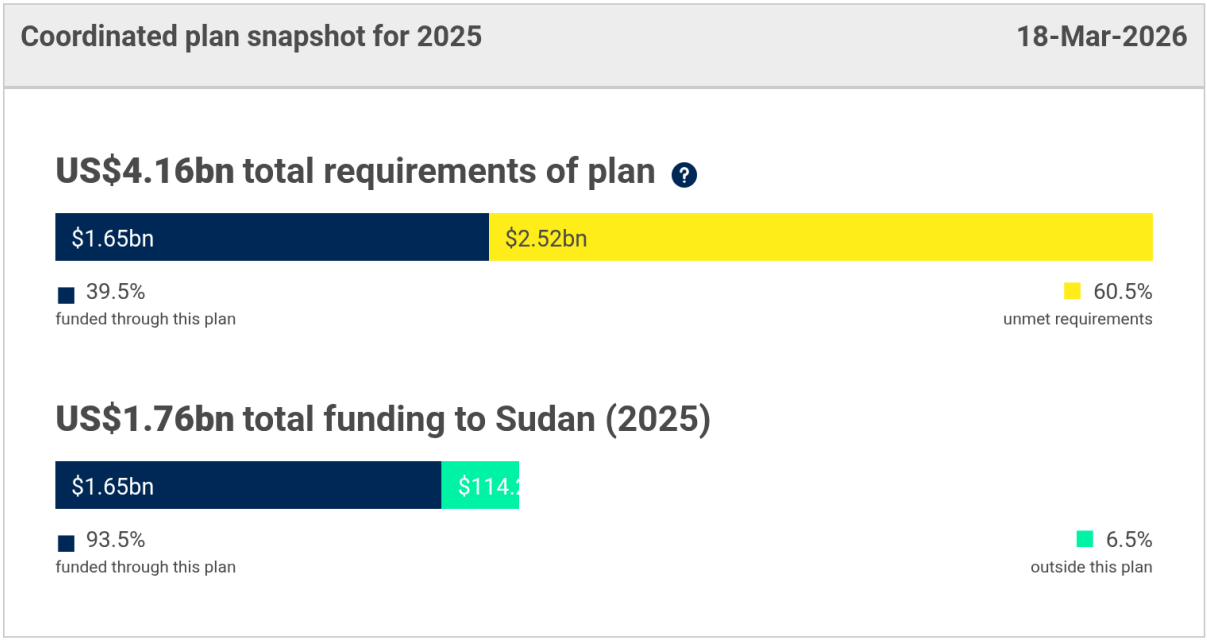
Funding for the Sudan response is coordinated through a structured and collaborative system, but it remains insufficient to meet needs (see Figures 4, 5 and 6 (below)) and is often unpredictable (UN). For 2025, OCHA reports that a total of USD 1.7 billion humanitarian funding was provided – only one third of the USD 4.2 billion in estimated needs. Approximately 43 % of these funds were used to address food insecurity.

Figure 4: EU and EU Member States ODA to Sudan since 2020



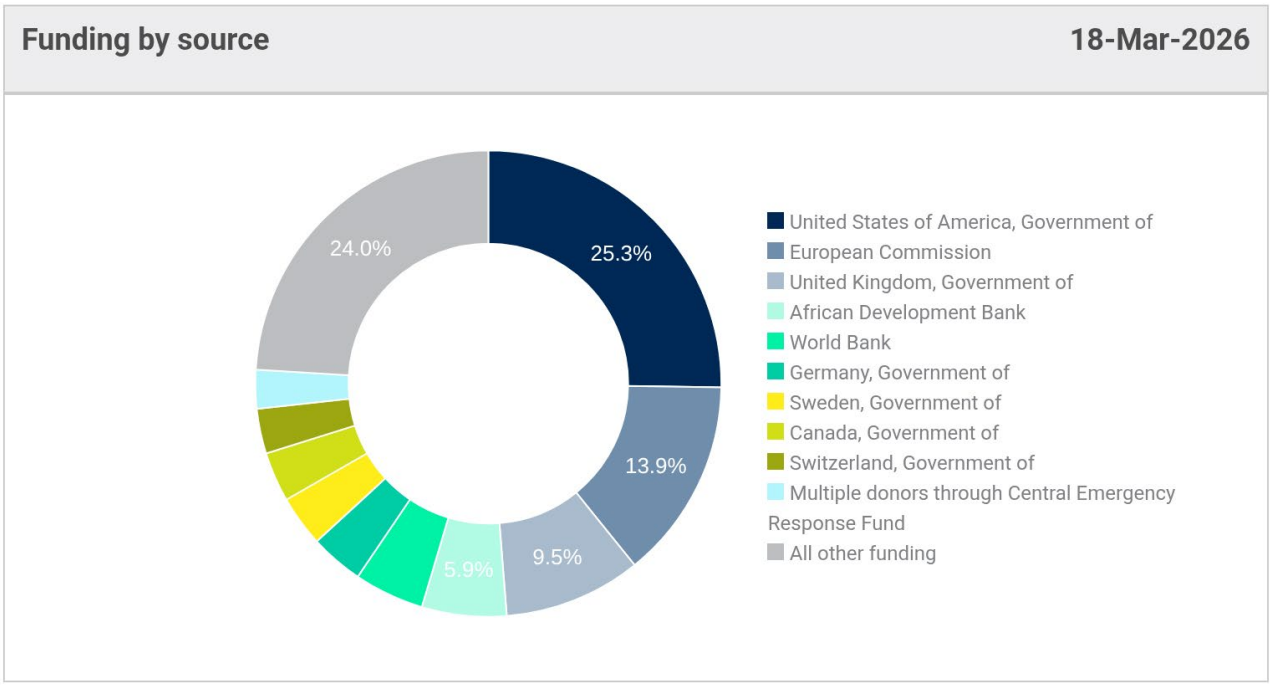
Source: OECD.

Figure 5: Unmet funding needs for Sudan (2025)



Source: UN OCHA services.

Figure 6: Funding received by Sudan by source



Source: UN OCHA services.

As discussed in section 4.1, donors can channel funding in three ways: directly funding operational partners, through a UN agency intermediary, or through pooled funding such as the SHF. When funding operational partners directly, donors select a specific sector, location, and implementing organisation listed in the HNRP for a particular sector and provide resources directly to an NGO or UN agency active in this sector. An alternative often used by donors is to rely on UN agencies as intermediaries because of their technical expertise. In such cases, agencies implement directly or award sub-grants to trusted local or international partners. While all these approaches within the aid architecture are structured, data-driven, and flexible in terms of channels, the core challenge is not coordination, but rather the limited resources, their unreliable replenishment and the challenges of delivering aid in some locations as discussed above (UN).

Even though local organisations are at the forefront of the humanitarian response in Sudan, many face significant barriers in accessing international funding (LS/CSO). Due diligence procedures, compliance requirements, and risk-mitigation standards are important safeguards for accountability. However, implementing partners report that meeting these requirements can be particularly challenging for smaller or community-based organisations operating in resource-constrained environments. For smaller, community-based organisations, these requirements can exceed their technical and administrative capacity, particularly when operating in conflict-affected and infrastructure-poor environments. In practical terms, applying for grants can be a challenge for these organisations as online application systems require stable internet access, reliable electricity, functioning computers, and trained administrative staff. As a result, local actors may be excluded from direct funding opportunities simply because they cannot meet technical submission requirements. This challenge is particularly acute for women-led organisations, including

associations representing women with disabilities, youth and adolescent girls, internally displaced women, and refugee communities (LS/CSO).

Interviewees have raised concerns regarding donor flexibility, arguing that implementing partners frequently perceive funding frameworks, particularly from large institutional donors, as rigid, with limited room for reprogramming when needs shift rapidly (LS/CSO). Lack of adaptability to change in circumstances can risk inefficiencies and, in some cases, a misalignment between activities and actual community needs. Reports from refugee rights organisations corroborate that this problem exists in Sudan to some extent, while also arguing that some progress to mitigate these problems has been made through the SHF.

5. EU response

The European Union is one of the key humanitarian donors to Sudan. It is active in Sudan on various levels, providing humanitarian assistance, development support, and diplomatic engagement. Following the evacuation from Khartoum at the beginning of the conflict, the EU has carried out actions and operations with staff based in Port Sudan (ECHO), Nairobi (ECHO), Cairo (EEAS, INTPA) and Europe (EU). Interviewees expressed strong appreciation for the European Union's sustained engagement in Sudan (LS/CSO). The EU's financial contributions during a period of global funding contraction are widely recognised. Equally important is the EU's political attention to Sudan through humanitarian meetings, senior officials' discussions, and continued inclusion of Sudan on the agenda. For many Sudanese actors, this visibility and advocacy are as important as financial assistance. Political will, diplomatic engagement, and sustained international attention are seen as essential components of support.

5.1 Humanitarian assistance

Humanitarian assistance in Sudan is managed by the European Commission's Directorate-General for Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations department (DG ECHO). According to figures from DG ECHO, in 2025, the overall EU contribution to the regional response to the Sudan crisis totalled EUR 269 million, of which EUR 160 million were allocated for lifesaving assistance to vulnerable populations in Sudan. This is a slight increase compared to the EUR 260 million mobilised in 2024, of which EUR 147 million were foreseen for the lifesaving assistance to vulnerable populations in Sudan.

EU humanitarian assistance focuses on the most urgent and life-saving needs, including food assistance and cash support; healthcare and primary medical services; nutritional treatment for children under five and pregnant or breastfeeding women; water, sanitation and hygiene; shelter and non-food items; protection services; and education in emergencies. Support extends not only to populations inside Sudan, but also to displaced communities and host countries, notably the Central African Republic, Chad, Egypt, Ethiopia, Libya and South Sudan (EU).

DG ECHO is the only EU service to have staff in Sudan. EU-funded humanitarian operations are primarily implemented through UN agencies, international humanitarian non governmental organisations and the Red Cross and Crescent family operating in Sudan and

the broader region (LS/CSO and EU). Every year, DG ECHO prepares and publishes 'Humanitarian Implementation Plans' (HIPs), which provide detailed information on the operational priorities for Sudan and other relevant countries. Partners can then submit proposals and, if selected, receive funding. Funding is often for one year. (EU) Many partners operate through local partners. All contracts have built-in flexibility to adapt to changes in location, activities, and priorities linked to the ongoing crisis and ensuring a targeted response (EU). Actions often include a 'crisis modifier', a contingency tool to respond to (or anticipate) a crisis within a crisis. This can take the form of a percentage of the budget available to the partner to adapt actions to unforeseen crises.

DG ECHO also supports a 'rapid response mechanism' and uses other tools, such as ReliefEU: the All-Emergencies Response Tool (ALERT) was used last year to respond to crises in Tawila, North Darfur (EU). Since the beginning of the conflict, the EU also organised 35 humanitarian air bridge (HAB) flights to transport over 2500 tonnes of assistance.

5.2 Development support

Beside humanitarian assistance, the EU is also active in development cooperation through the Directorate-General for International Partnerships (DG INTPA). Before the war, numerous development programmes were underway in Sudan, implemented in partnership with CSOs, NGOs, EU Member States' agencies, and the UN, with no funding given to the government (EU). To respond to the new reality and the associated security and operational challenges, the majority of the programs were continued with additional funding.

Under the Neighbourhood, Development and International Cooperation Instrument – Global Europe (NDICI – Global Europe), development support is usually carried out through multi-annual indicative programs (MIPs). The complex political context of Sudan had already led DG INTPA to implement individual measures outside of the MIP before the war (EU). In 2023, a budget of EUR 130 million was allocated for food security and resilience, and for primary health, which also includes nutrition (EU). In 2024, EUR 95 million was allocated to programmes focusing on protecting human rights, employment and youth skills, and primary education and school feeding (EU). EU development support addresses the essential needs of vulnerable groups, including children and young people, women and girls, and persons with disabilities. Support also targets displaced and host communities in Sudan.

Coordination between DG INTPA and DG ECHO is essential, and development and humanitarian actions are therefore closely linked (EU). DG INTPA and DG ECHO are closely cooperating and in regular contact. While DG ECHO manages humanitarian activities and immediate assistance to people in need, DG INTPA focuses on mid- to long-term impact – for example, supporting or strengthening existing capacities and institutions at the local level. Development support is primarily focussed in areas impacted by a large influx of people and focussed on reinforcing basic services and systems still in operation. One way in which development assistance functions in this way is by working with schools to provide food for students in collaboration with local smallholder farmers as suppliers. This provides

income to farmers and incentivises families to send their children to school as it can improve their food security as well as school attendance.

5.3 Diplomatic action

The EU is also carrying out diplomatic action with political engagement designed to address the causes, dynamics, and consequences of the conflict. A first, essential component of the EU's response to the humanitarian crisis in Sudan is advocacy. The EU consistently calls for full compliance with international humanitarian law, particularly with regard to the protection of civilians and the guarantee of safe, unhindered humanitarian access (EU). In practical terms, the EU advocates for the removal of administrative and security obstacles that impede humanitarian operations. This includes waiving travel restrictions for humanitarian personnel, granting permits for movement beyond Port Sudan, ensuring safe passage by road and air, fast-tracking visa applications, and easing customs procedures to accelerate the import of essential supplies. The EU also stresses that humanitarian actors must be allowed to operate independently and neutrally, throughout the country, wherever the needs are.

In addition, the EU has amplified international attention to the crisis through public statements and high-level diplomatic events. It has issued more than 19 formal statements since the outbreak of the war, including a recent joint statement on the protection of civilians and humanitarian operations by Commissioner Hadja Lahbib joined by 32 countries. The EU has also co-organised major international gatherings, including the Fourth Humanitarian Senior Officials Meeting in Brussels in March 2026 and the Berlin Sudan Conference on 15 April 2026, which aim to mobilise political support and needed resources (EU).

Beside advocacy, the EU plays an active mediatory role (EU). EU mediation efforts promote inclusive negotiations that incorporate civilian actors alongside political and military stakeholders with the overarching objective to support ceasefire talks, protect civilians throughout Sudan, and restore respect for the rule of law, accountability, and international humanitarian and human rights law. The European Union Special Representative (EUSR) for the Horn of Africa, Annette Weber, works to consolidate the various overlapping peace initiatives into a more unified international platform, coordinating closely with the African Union, the Intergovernmental Authority on Development, the United Nations, and the League of Arab States.

Diplomatic engagement at the national level remains at the core of the EU's approach (EU). Even though it has so far condemned the RSF and the SAF equally, the EU and its Member States maintain dialogue with Sudanese authorities, political actors, civil society organisations, women and youth groups, private sector representatives, and community leaders (EU). These consultations aim to address the root causes of the conflict and bridge divisions among Sudanese stakeholders in the hope of reaching a comprehensive and inclusive political settlement. The prolonged conflict severely undermines humanitarian conditions, sustainable development, and critical infrastructure, and risks depleting national resources and destabilising the wider region.

Restrictive measures form another component of the EU's response (EU). While not the sole instrument, sanctions are intended to signal accountability and exert pressure on individuals and entities responsible for undermining peace, violating human rights, or obstructing humanitarian access. These measures complement diplomatic and humanitarian engagement by reinforcing the EU's consistent message: that violations of international law and actions that prolong the conflict carry consequences. Currently, EU sanctions apply to 18 individuals and 8 entities with affiliations to different armed groups. Five RSF affiliated individuals and two SAF affiliated individuals were sanctioned by the Council in January 2026 for 'causing irreparable costs to human life in Darfur and throughout the country, as well as violations of international human rights law and international humanitarian law'.

6. Position of the European Parliament

The European Parliament has adopted several resolutions on the conflict and situation in Sudan since its outbreak in 2023. In June 2023, the EP adopted a resolution on 'the humanitarian situation in Sudan, in particular the death of children trapped by fighting' in which Parliament condemns the violence, calls for an end to hostilities, and deplores obstructions of humanitarian access and attacks on humanitarian workers.

This was echoed by the EP resolution on 'the threat of famine following the spread of the conflict in Sudan', adopted on 18 March 2024. In the resolution, the EP specifically singles out the conflict as the reason for the high levels of food insecurity in Sudan, calling for unhindered humanitarian access to help civilians in need.

The EP resolution on the 'severe political, humanitarian and human rights crisis in Sudan, in particular sexual violence and child rape' adopted on 13 March 2025, repeats these points, but specifically condemns widespread sexual violence against women and children committed by both parties to the war.

On 27 November 2025, the EP adopted its latest resolution on Sudan, titled 'the escalation of the war and the humanitarian catastrophe in Sudan'. The resolution calls for opening humanitarian corridors and condemns 'the grave atrocities committed by the RSF in El Fasher and across the rest of Sudan, including widespread, ethnically targeted killings and violence, rape and sexual enslavement, torture, enforced disappearances, attacks on hospitals and humanitarian facilities, and the deliberate starvation of civilians, possibly constituting acts of genocide.'

On 11 November 2025, the European Parliament's Sub-Committee on Human Rights and the Committee on Development, held a public hearing on the human rights situation in Sudan and the relevant EU strategy. This discussion examined the situation on the ground and considered how the European Union could strengthen its response, alleviate the suffering of the Sudanese people, and contribute to a path for justice and peace.

7. Conclusions

Sudan is facing a multidimensional crisis marked by mass displacement, risk of famine, systemic human rights violations, collapse of essential services, and widespread failures of protection. The scale of humanitarian needs, affecting nearly two thirds of the population,

requires sustained funding and improved humanitarian access, stronger protection mechanisms, and coordinated international engagement. Without a significant increase in political attention and financial support, the humanitarian and human rights situation is likely to deteriorate further, with profound consequences for Sudan and the wider region.

The crisis in Sudan requires a complex response that combines immediate life-saving assistance at scale; with medium- to long-term assistance for issues such as psychosocial rehabilitation and income-generating activities. Humanitarian access in Sudan is constrained by a combination of administrative fragmentation, politicised permit systems, security threats, and deliberate obstruction. Until high-level advocacy by the EU and other actors reduces these barriers, the reality on the ground will require constant negotiation, community engagement, and diplomacy to ensure that life-saving assistance can reach those most in need. Weak or absent internet connectivity, recurring power cuts, and reliance on limited satellite infrastructure severely constrain effective coordination at the state and local level. Addressing these infrastructure gaps could ensure more inclusive participation, reduce operational disruptions, and strengthen coordination mechanisms beyond the capital.

Interviewees highlighted the importance of the EU response in Sudan, as the Union is a leading humanitarian donor, providing humanitarian aid, development support, and diplomatic engagement in response to the ongoing conflict. At the same time, interviews with local stakeholders underlined the need for more accessible, adaptable, and inclusive funding, ensuring that those closest to affected communities are not only implementers, but also partners in shaping the response.

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